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NATION | P2

**Abu Dhabi's Arts
and Flowers
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THE VIEWS | P8

**Trump and
Musk: Allies or
adversaries?**



MIDDLE EAST | P9

**US temporarily
eases Syria
sanctions**

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Massive earthquake kills 126 in Tibet

THOUSANDS OF BUILDINGS DESTROYED; 188 WOUNDED



AFP

■ Some of the houses in Shigatse, southwestern China's Tibet region, that collapsed after an earthquake hit the area yesterday. The tremors were also felt in Nepal and parts of India.

BEIJING

A devastating earthquake in China's remote Tibet region killed at least 126 people and damaged thousands of buildings yesterday, state media reported, with tremors also felt in neighbouring Nepal's capital Kathmandu and parts of India.

Videos published by China's state broadcaster CCTV showed houses destroyed with walls torn apart.

Rescue workers waded through rubble strewn across the ruins in the aftermath, footage showed, while some gave locals thick blankets to keep warm in subzero temperatures.

The quake struck rural, high-altitude Tingri county, about 80km north of Mount Everest near China's border with Nepal, at around 9am (0100 GMT).

"Here the houses are made from dirt so when the earthquake came... lots of houses collapsed," said 34-year-old Sangji Dangzhi, whose supermarket in Tingri suffered considerable damage.

'Very serious' situation

Speaking to AFP by phone, Sangji described the situation as "very serious", with ambulances taking people to hospital throughout the day.

Surveillance images published by CCTV showed people running through a store's aisles as shelves shook vio-

3,400
rescuers, over 340
medical workers at
the quake site

lently, sending objects like toys tumbling to the ground.

At least 126 people have been confirmed dead and 188 others injured as of 7pm, CCTV said. Twenty-eight people in critical condition were transferred to hospital for treatment and 3,609 houses had collapsed, it added.

The China Earthquake Networks Center (CENC) measured the quake's magnitude as 6.8, while the US Geological Survey reported it as 7.1.

'All-out rescue efforts'
Tingri, the epicentre, is home to around 62,000 people, and is much less developed than urban centres like Tibet's capital Lhasa.

Temperatures in Tingri are projected to drop to minus 16 degrees Celsius overnight, according to the China Meteorological Administration.

Authorities said more than 3,400 rescuers and over 340 medical workers had been deployed.

— AFP

UAE company set to invest \$20b in US data centres, Trump reveals

Damac founder confirms foray into American market

DUBAI

BY DHANUSHA GOKULAN
Chief Reporter

President-elect Donald Trump yesterday announced an investment of at least \$20 billion from Hussain Sajwani, the head of Dubai's Damac Group, to build new data centres in the US.

"They may go double, or even somewhat more than double, that amount of mon-

ey," Trump said of Sajwani's company.

Confirming the announcement to *Gulf News*, Sajwani said: "This is an extremely exciting moment for us. Our foray into the US market in data centres represents a significant milestone in our journey to build a global digital infrastructure platform that will empower businesses today and in the future.

"Leveraging our expertise in real estate and data centres, we aim to deliver best-in-class infrastructure that supports the next wave of cloud and AI growth, helping further to po-

sition the US in the technology and global data ecosystem."

Trump said the first phase of the investments would be in the states of Texas, Arizona, Oklahoma, Louisiana, Ohio, Illinois, Michigan and Indiana, painting it as critical to keeping the US competitive in emerging technologies. "The investment will support massive new data centres across the Midwest, the Sun Belt area, and also to keep America on the cutting edge of technology and artificial intelligence," he said at a press conference at his Mar-a-Lago resort in Florida yesterday.

— With inputs from agencies

NATION

**How stroke
victim,
psychiatric
patient got UAE
amnesty | P3**

BUSINESS

**Dubai hospitals
await rush after
UAE-wide
health coverage
kicks in | P5**

ENTERTAINMENT

**Malayalam star
Unni Mukundan
defends his
controversial
hit Marco | P16**



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Meta to end policy of fact-checking

Decision applies only to social media users in America

NEW YORK

Meta Platforms Inc. will end third-party fact checking on its social media platforms in the US, letting users comment on posts' accuracy with a community notes system it said will promote free expression.

Content moderation systems across the company's platforms, which include Facebook, Instagram and Threads, have "gone too far," and are blocking users' free expression too often, Joel Kaplan, Meta's chief global affairs officer, said in a blog post yesterday.

'Facebook jail'

"Too much harmless content gets censored, too many people find themselves wrongly locked up in 'Facebook jail,' and we are often too slow to respond when they do," said Kaplan, a former adviser to the George W. Bush White House who was named head of global affairs

this month. The company will also make it easier for people who want to see more political posts to get additional content on their feeds.

The move to remove the system that was set up in 2016 to combat viral hoaxes aligns Meta more closely with Elon Musk's X, which also relies on user notes to police accuracy on the site.

It may be more risky to remove fact checkers in the rest of the world, particularly Europe, where Meta is subject to European Union regulations requiring it to combat misinformation. The EU requires large platforms to actively cull deceptive political content and disinformation or risk heavy fines.

— Bloomberg

**The move to remove
the system that was set
up in 2016 to combat
viral hoaxes aligns
Meta more closely
with Elon Musk's X,
which also relies on
user notes to police
accuracy on the site.**



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